BOOKISHBAE

Letters I Never Sent

Nine short stories

Annu

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters and incidents are the product of the author's imagination.

First edition.

The Eleventh Draft

Dear Appa, he wrote, and then looked at it for eleven minutes, which was longer than he had looked at anything in Dubai.

The first draft had been four pages and had contained the word "suffocating", which he had deleted on the grounds that it was true. The fourth had been a single line. The seventh had opened with a joke about the weather and had gone downhill from there, as things that open with jokes about the weather tend to.

This one, the eleventh, he had decided, would simply contain the information. He was not going back. The flat had been given up. The money, what was left of it, was in a fixed deposit in his mother's name, which was not an accident and which his father would understand immediately.

He wrote all of that. It took four lines. Then he wrote, underneath, I know what you gave up to send me, and that is the part I cannot find a way to say, and then he folded the page twice and put it in the drawer with the other ten, and went downstairs, and told him.

A Good Tenant

Mr. Pinto had been a terrible tenant and an exhausting human being, and the family had asked Mr. Siqueira, as the landlord of eleven years, to say a few words.

He began three times. Each time the sentence that arrived was true, and each time he recognised that nobody at a funeral wants the truth, they want the shape of it.

He went to find the rent book instead. Eleven years of entries in his own hand: paid, paid, paid late, paid, a gap of four months in 2019 with a pencil note saying hospital, then paid, paid, paid.

At the service he said: he paid his rent for eleven years, and in all that time he never once asked me for anything, and I never once asked him how he was. Then he sat down, and the daughter looked at him for a long moment, and nodded.

The Other Shortlist

The letter was addressed to a woman she had never met and would have recognised anywhere, because there was a photograph of her in a shoebox in the spare room, and because her husband said her name in the particular neutral tone people reserve for names they have practised being neutral about.

Dear Anjali, she wrote. I am not writing this to be cruel and I am certainly not going to send it.

What followed was two pages, of which only the last paragraph surprised her as she wrote it. I think the version of him you knew would have been easier to live with, it said. I think I got the one who had already decided to be careful. I do not know which of us got the better end of that and I have stopped trying to find out.

She read it back, corrected a comma, and put it in the drawer. It is still there. It is, she would tell you if you asked her, the kindest thing she has ever written about her own marriage.